

Modified Essay Questions (MEQ's)

Modified Essay Question A

John is a 55 yr. old principal of a local school who is referred to you privately, by his health practitioner (GP) for further assessment and treatment.

He had a myocardial infarction 6 months ago. He is a successful teacher and lives with his wife and three children. He has been trialled on three different SSRI's without any benefit.

Question A1

Outline John's causes for treatment resistance and the salient features you would look for in assessment (8 marks)

Question A2

During your assessment he tells you that he is certain that he is unable to provide for his family and that they are facing financial ruin. He is growingly increasingly despondent about this. He says he cannot afford to come and see you. His wife finds him pacing about during the day and reports that there is no issue financially and that despite any reassurances from work or family, he continues to worry about the future. His wife says that he stays up all night pacing.

Outline the key aspects of your management plan you would consider at this stage (10 marks)

Question A3

John has been reluctantly seeing you monthly. He tells you that the work environment has become unbearable. After an incident at work, which involved an altercation with students, John has taken time off due to sickness. 5 months later you receive a letter from WorkCover outlining that they need a report from you regarding John. They have also sent you a request for his notes.

List the key points in your approach to this request (3 marks)

Question A4

John's mental state deteriorates over the next few months. You admit him to a private hospital. 6 days into the admission you receive a phone call from the ward stating that John has committed suicide.

Outline how you would proceed (5 Marks)

- a. List the approach to a patient who is in debt and has financial stress.

Modified Essay Question B

Stan is a 20-year-old indigenous male. He has been admitted to the mental health unit after a violent assault on his father. His parents report that he has not been himself over the last 6 months and has been seen talking to himself on a number of occasions. He also is reported to smoke cannabis on a regular basis.

Question B1

List the short and long-term risk factors you would assess for in this case that would increase the risk of violence?

Question B2

Following your assessment of Stan an indigenous male, you diagnose him with schizophrenia. His medical investigations are normal. You find out that he has been admitted previously to another mental health unit where he was diagnosed with schizophrenia. He was started on Risperidone 6 mg, which he stopped 9 months ago. He continues to complain of ongoing auditory hallucinations but refuses to take any medication.

Outline your approach to this situation.

List the factors affecting compliance in this case?

Outline how you would specifically address his resistant hallucinations after finding out he was compliant with medication.

Question B3

After a 4-week admission Stan is better. The family is concerned about his being discharged in the community as it is an indigenous community and his parents are worried about the impact of this on Stan's mental health. They do not want any community follow up from the CMHT but want to go to the traditional healer.

How would you manage this situation?

- I. **You have an obese patient with depression and diabetes? The endocrinologist has reported that your patient has to lose weight to prevent the onset of Insulin dependent Diabetes Mellitus. During the interview when you bring up the topic of losing weight, she says, “I don’t need to follow my diet as long as I’m feeling OK.”**

Outline your approach to the situation to assist the patient in losing weight.

- II. **A 52-year-old female who takes 2 antidepressants, 2 mood stabilisers and 2 antipsychotics along with metformin and anti-hypertensive reports that she is finding it difficult to remember to take her medication.**

List the strategies to assist her.

III. A 21-year-old female has been recently diagnosed with an eating disorder.

List the factors you would focus on in developing your formulation

Modified Essay Question C

Jane is a 16-year-old female referred by her GP. She lives with her parents and younger sister. She presented to the GP with nausea and vomiting. Her medical investigations revealed a low potassium. The GP feels that she may have an eating disorder.

Question C1

List the salient features in history, examination and formulation you would focus on to make a diagnosis

Modified Essay Question C continued

Following your assessment, you make a diagnosis of Anorexia Nervosa. She has a BMI of 14. On the paediatric ward where she has been admitted, she refuses to eat and threatens to kill herself if given food. The nursing staff has become hostile against the patient. They ask you to have her transferred to the psychiatric ward.

Question C2

Outline your immediate management plan?

Modified Essay Question C continued

She continues to remain on the paediatric ward. Her behaviour has settled. Her parents come to meet you to discuss management of their daughter's condition. They feel that they are to blame for her condition.

Question C3

Outline the key points you would cover in the discussion?

a. What are the symptoms of refeeding syndrome and how do you manage it?

IV. A 71-year-old Vietnam veteran has a long-standing history of PTSD. He reported a traumatic upbringing with sexual abuse.

a. List the main factors that would explain the development of PTSD (including others not in the vignette).

b. What are the treatment strategies for PTSD?

Modified Essay Question D

Maria, aged 25 years, has a history of epilepsy since early childhood with multiple seizure types, a poor response to anticonvulsants, and longstanding cognitive difficulties (her full-scale IQ is 65). She lives with her parents in a small country town, and intermittently attends a supported work program packing boxes of fruit.

She was admitted in status epilepticus to a tertiary intensive care unit and was ventilated for 3 days. Two days ago, she was transferred to the neurology ward. Since waking up she has been telling her parents that “everyone is spying on me with satellite cameras”, and that the nursing staff are saying horrible things about her. She is worried that the food is poisoned.

You are asked by the neurology team to see Maria.

Question D1

Discuss the information you would seek prior to seeing Maria. Please give reasons for your answers. (12 marks)

Question D2

Maria experiences another seizure and is now under observation in the neurology ward. Maria attempts to abscond from the ward on a number of occasions and the nursing staff call you as her parents have arrived and want to take Maria home. They believe that the treatment is “not doing her any good”. The nursing staff call you for advice.

Outline your immediate management plan.

Question D3

The neurologist is happy for Maria to remain under her care, as the risk of further seizures is quite high. However, the nursing ward staff have now become anxious about managing Maria on the neurology ward because they feel she is “crazy” and may be a danger to the other sick patients.

Describe how you would address the nursing staff’s concerns. (7 marks)

Modified Essay Question E

You are a psychiatric registrar working in the Drug and alcohol service. Rhonda is a 35-year-old female with 3 children. She lives with her partner who is 37. She has a history of Drug and Alcohol misuse since the age of 19. She had been a heavy user of cannabis, alcohol, and heroin. She continues to use heroin, which she buys off the streets.

Question E1

Discuss the salient features you would cover in history, examination and formulation in Rhonda's assessment

Question E2

You are contacted by the Department of human services to provide a report on Rhonda's capacity to look after her children.

Outline the key points you would cover (List the key principles in approaching this request and what are the key components of a parenting assessment?)

Question E3

6 months later, Rhonda is abstinent from heroin and wants to have another child with her partner. She is on a routine outpatient's review and wants to know your opinion about having a baby.

What points will you cover during this interview?

QUESTION 11

A 41-year-old female presented to the emergency department found to be unconscious following an overdose. She has a past history of several presentations with deliberate self-harm. On medical work up it was found that she has atrial fibrillation too and was treated in a medical ward.

11.1. List the differential diagnoses

11.2. The medical team decides that she needs to be treated with warfarin and they want your advice. What is your advice to the medical team?

11.3. The lady is discharged back home with follow up in the community via a community care team. Devise a management plan for the next three months, which you will present to your consultant.

QUESTION 12

A 39-year-old school teacher was referred by her GP due to long term addiction to morphine tablets. Her husband has long term back pain. She has three children (15, 12 and 7). She confirms that she does not use them while at work but uses only two tablets at night-time. She has no anxiety or depression.

12.1. Describe your assessment

12.2. Outline the key steps in management

12.3. In one of her subsequent visits she tells you that her 7-year old daughter is showing anxiety and is clinging on to her. She is also rebellious and is showing argumentative and defiant behaviour.

List the possible contributory factors for this behaviour.

QUESTION 13

A 35-year-old migrant lady from India and mother of a child who is 5 was admitted to the ED following a seizure in a supermarket. Her husband works far away from home and comes home only on weekends. He is unsupportive of her and she has minimal social support.

The emergency department assessment revealed that investigations are normal and medical registrar diagnoses this as a pseudoseizure and wants you to assess the lady.

13.1. Outline the approach to the assessment.

13.2. Her husband calls angrily and says that she is acting out and does not have any medical grounds to be admitted. He wants her to be discharged home.

How would you respond to the situation?

QUESTION 14

A 75-year-old female who was suffering from Parkinsonism for 15 years was admitted to change the batteries of her pacemaker. On the second day after changing the batteries she had become disoriented, experiencing visual hallucinations. She lives with her 80-year-old husband and was managed by the GP. You are called by the medical team to see this lady. She was on lorazepam nocte on a long-term basis, but the medical team stopped her lorazepam.

14.1. Describe your assessment of this lady with your differential diagnoses.

14.3. Write down your medication advice for the medical team.

14.4. The medical team decide to discharge her. What advice would you give to them before discharge?

QUESTION 15

A young man is brought to the emergency department on a hunger strike. He is physically debilitated when presented. He is a cubicle with two other people in it. You are asked to see this patient?

15.1. List the ethical considerations in this case.

15.2. Patient was given feeds and was medically stabilised after several weeks. The medical team inform you that they are going to discharge him.

What are the key points you would like to assess before discharging him?

QUESTION 16

A 32-year old Caucasian female who lives with three children is referred to you for sleep disturbance. She says she has been diagnosed with chronic fatigue syndrome and is preoccupied with aches and pains in her joints. She says she is constantly tired during the day.

16.1. Describe your assessment

16.2.

You diagnose her with depression. She reports that she had a family history of bipolar affective disorder in her family. Her mother also had thyroid dysfunction. Growing up she was prone to infections and often spent several months in hospital for severe urinary tract infections. She missed school as a result. Her parents were critical of her and favoured her brother. Her mother was addicted to benzodiazepines and she described her mother as emotionally distant. She performed poorly at school and was below average. She was bullied at school for being overweight. She tells you that currently her pain and fatigue prevent her from going to work and that the only thing that gives her relief is Lorazepam.

Outline the key contributory factors to this patient's depression providing justification from the vignette.

QUESTION 17

A 25-year-old Caucasian female who is a known patient of the mental health team is 24 weeks pregnant and presents to you in crisis as she has an upcoming court case for custody of her 3-year-old child.

17.1. List the key points you would cover in your assessment

QUESTION 18

A Vietnam Veteran aged 67 presents to the emergency department late at night. The nursing staff call you to assess him as he has a ligature mark around his neck. On assessment he tells you that he was “mucking about” and that he had no intention of dying. He smells of alcohol.

18.1. List the key points in management

QUESTION 19

You are a consultant psychiatrist in a community mental health team. The GP has referred Mandy, a 35-year-old Caucasian female with depressive symptoms for diagnostic clarification. Mandy's brother died 3 months ago in a car crash.

19.1. Outline the key differential diagnoses you would consider to assist the GP.

QUESTION 20

You are a Consultant Psychiatrist in the community mental health team. You are seeing Mr Smith a 34-year-old junior medical officer who has been referred by his director of training for psychiatric evaluation. The director of training tells you that the medical officer has appeared drowsy during the morning shifts and suspects addiction.

20.1. Outline your approach to management.

Modified Essay Question F

Mary is a 36-year-old married woman. Three months ago, she gave birth to twins via emergency caesarean section, born at 26 weeks. Her son Dennis died. Her daughter Kym is in neonatal ICU on a respiratory ventilator. Mary has remained in hospital since the birth. Nursing staff say Mary is frequently tearful and criticises their care of Kym. Nursing staff have begun avoiding being assigned to Kym because of this.

Her husband James is an accountant who works long hours and visits for around an hour at a time. Her parents live nearby but say they are reluctant to visit as they “cannot stand seeing the baby like that”.

Question F1

Discuss how you would assess Mary’s attachment to Kym

Question F2

You diagnose Mary with post-natal depression. She is expressing breast milk to bottle-feed and is keen to continue this.

Describe the content of your discussion with Mary and her husband regarding the use of antidepressants and breast feeding.

Question F3

**Nursing staff report Mary is difficult and ask your advise on how to handle her.
Discuss your response to this request**

Modified Essay Question G

A 35-year-old female with an established diagnosis of Bipolar Disorder is on Lithium 900 mg daily for the last 2 years. She has been stable with no relapses over the last 2 years. She attends your outpatient clinic and tells you that she has just come from her GP's rooms who sent her here as she is now 8 weeks pregnant. You have not seen her before.

Question G1

Outline your approach to the situation.

Modified Essay Question H

A 39-year-old female with a 2-year history of depression has recently had a course of ECT (6 months ago). Over the last month she is complaining of worsening memory and slowing of her mind.

Question H1

Outline the key features in assessment that you would focus on to evaluate the memory complaints

Modified Essay Question I

Mr Alan Woods is a 64-year old male who is brought to the CMHT by his daughter due to a change in personality. His daughter reports that he has been doing odd things and has said inappropriate things to his grandchildren.

Question I1

Describe your assessment with respect to establishing the diagnosis?

Question 12

You diagnose him with Alzheimer's dementia. His daughter tells you that she has read that dementia can be hereditary and wants to know if her family should be tested.

What issues would you discuss?

Question 13

A few months later Mr Woods has a fracture of his femur and is admitted to the surgical unit. After the operation, Mr Woods has developed gangrene of his foot. He refuses to have this operated. The surgeons call you to speak to Mr woods.

How would you manage the situation?

Modified Essay Question J

John is a 22-year-old male with Down's syndrome who lives in a residential home for people with learning difficulties. You are a psychiatric registrar working in the emergency department. The ED registrar refers John's case to you after John was verbally and physically aggressive to staff in the residential home. The staff refuse to have him at the home until his behaviour has settled.

Question J1

Outline how you would assess the situation with a view to clarify the diagnosis?

Question J2

John 's behaviour settled, and he went to the residential home. The staff ask for particular strategies to manage John's behaviour when he gets aggressive.

Outline the key points you would cover in your discussion?

Question J3

John has developed a relationship with a 24-year-old female in the nursing home. The staff are concerned and so are John's parents. John's parents do not want him to have a relationship with the female in the nursing home.

What are the main issues to be addressed in this situation?

Modified Essay Question K

Jane is a 35-year-old nurse working in an in-patient unit where you work as the psychiatric registrar. Steven is a 35-year-old male who presents to the reception of the in-patient unit demanding to see Jane. He claims that he is in love with her and wants to see her immediately. He seems agitated. Jane reports to you that she does not know him, and he has been following her lately. She mentions that he has been an inpatient on the unit 3 months ago.

Question K1

Describe your assessment and what are the key features you would like to focus on with a view to diagnosis (10 Marks)

Question K2

You have diagnosed Steven with Psychosis and want to admit him. There are no other beds available and he will need to be admitted on the ward of the local hospital. Jane, the nurse will be working double shifts for the next week.

Outline your immediate management plan.

Question K3

Jane the in-patient nurse has been traumatised by the overall experience and comes to you for advice. She reports feeling constantly on edge and believes this is affecting her work. She tells you that she has developed a dislike for the young male patients on the ward.

List the key issues in management

a. What are the components of a sexual reoffending programme?

b. List the treatments for paraphilias

Modified Essay Question L

You are a psychiatry registrar working in CAMHS. Jack is a 10-year-old boy who lives with his mother Lucy 32 and his father Rob 37. He has a younger sister Mary who is 6 years of age. The GP has referred Jack to your service, as he has been very difficult to handle. His teachers are complaining that he is disruptive, and his academic performance is deteriorating.

Question L1

Describe your assessment of Jack with a view to a differential diagnosis.

Question L2

After the assessment you diagnose him with ADHD.

Describe the strategies for management

Modified Essay Question M

You work in a Child and Adolescent Outpatient Clinic and a paediatrician has sent you a referral. 10-year-old boy attends with his mother. He lives at home with parents and siblings. The paediatrician has diagnosed him with ADHD and Tourette's and has prescribed him methylphenidate and clonidine with improvement of behaviours at home. His school performance has, however, deteriorated.

Question M1

What are some of the possible reasons for his poor school performance?

Question M2

Mother reports she has read in a magazine article that stimulants cause growth retardation and “drug addicts”.

How do you respond to mother’s concern about medication?

Modified Essay Question M continued

You continue to prescribe him his medication and his school performance improves. However, his mother is concerned about on-going tics.

Question M3

Outline your management of his Tourette's.

Modified Essay Question N

You are the consultant of an inpatient psychiatric ward. Your patient is a 51-year-old man with psychotic depression. He appears to be improving with medication, so his nursing observations are downgraded. When you arrive to work early Monday morning, you are informed that your patient has committed suicide over the weekend. He was found hanging in his bedroom on the ward.

Question N1

What is your immediate response to this situation?

Modified Essay Question N continued

Your patient's ex-wife calls you. She has been informed by the police of the death. She asks for advice on what to tell their 10-year-old son. He last saw his father 2 months ago. She is not sure whether to tell him about the suicide.

Question N2

Outline your response?

Modified Essay Question N continued

During the week you notice that the nursing staff are reluctant to downgrade nursing observations or to let inpatients go on leave. They request more nursing staff as they report they are unable to provide adequate nursing care.

Question N3

What are the possible reasons why the nursing staff are behaving like this?
What are the key strategies in managing this?

Modified Essay Question O

You are the consultant of a community mental health clinic. Your patient is a 49-year-old Indigenous woman who has been case managed and treated for symptoms of PTSD for the last 6 months following a sexual assault 2 months. On her way to her appointment today, she saw her assailant, who is a distant relative, on the bus and became very distressed. Her case manager has just approached you with concerns about the level of her distress and risk of self-harm.

Question O1

Before assessing your patient, what information do you need from the case manager?

Modified Essay Question O continued

You see your patient with her case manager. She reports after speaking to you she feels much better. She denies any self-harm ideation and does not want to be admitted to hospital. She would like to go home and would like something to “make me feel better and help me sleep tonight”.

Question O2

What is your immediate management plan?

Modified Essay Question O continued

A week later the case manager approaches you and informs you that your patient is feeling much better after speaking about her symptoms. Your patient would like to disclose the sexual assault to her adult daughter. However, she is concerned that her adult son, and other members of the community will find out.

Question O3

What is your response to the case manager?